

C7. Key concepts and theories for studying Social Media



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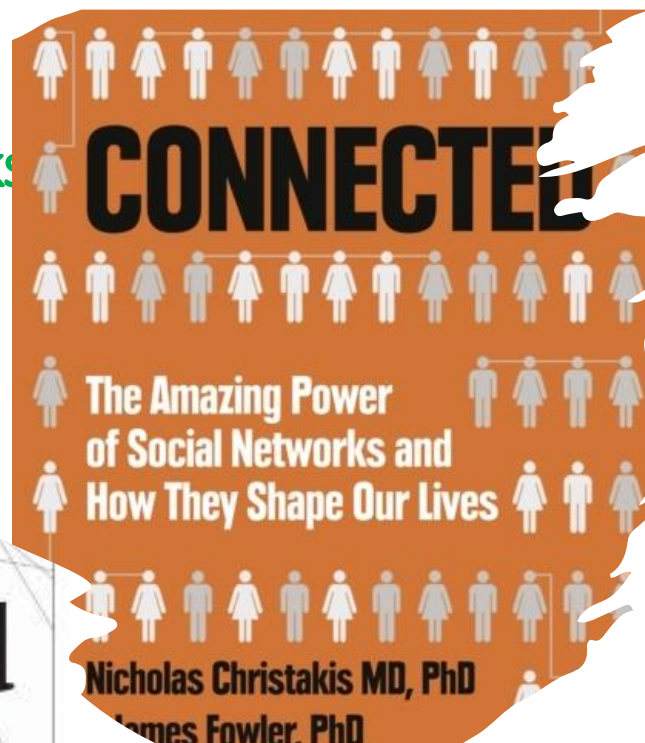
Assoc. Prof. Arabela BRICIU

Why do social networks exist and how do they influence us?



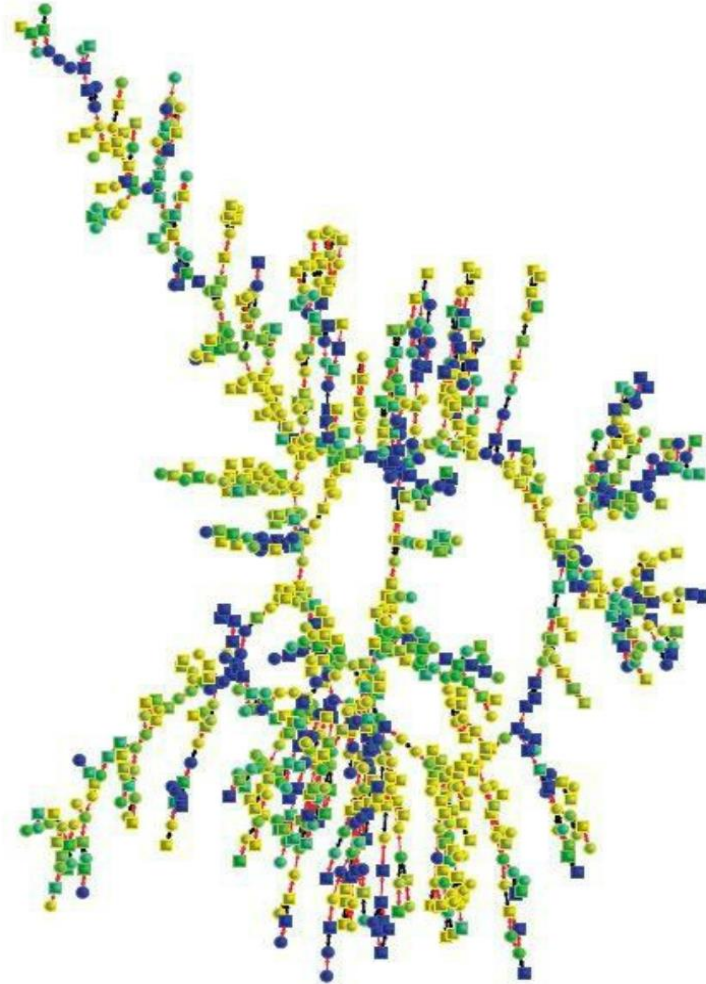
Dr. Nicholas A.
CHRISTAKIS
Dr. James H.
FOWLER

Puterea surprinzătoare
a rețetelor sociale
și felul în care
ne modelează viața



Five rules regarding connection and contagion—the structure and function—of social networks
Christakis and Fowler (2009, pp. 16-26):

1. WE SHAPE OUR NETWORK
2. OUR NETWORK SHAPES US
3. OUR FRIENDS AFFECT US
4. OUR FRIENDS' FRIENDS' FRIENDS AFFECT US
5. THE NETWORK HAS A LIFE OF ITS OWN

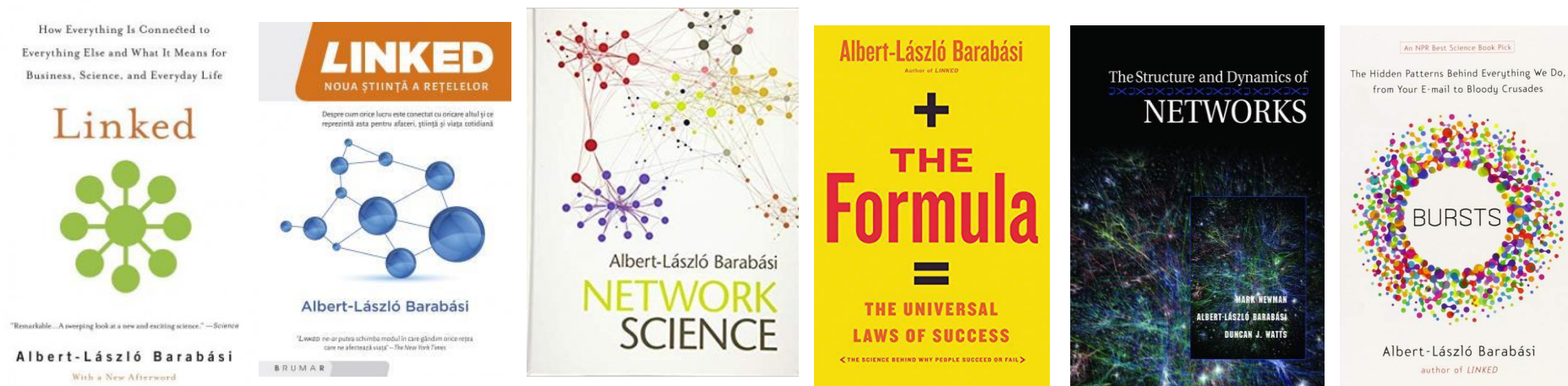


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- Source: Christakis & Fowler (2009, p. 296)

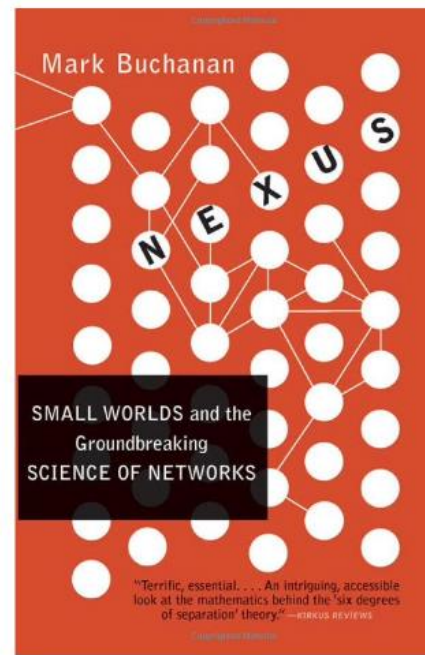
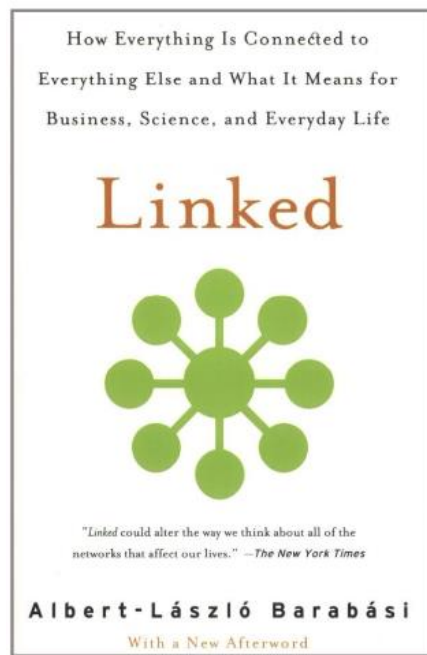
Plate 1. A network of 1,020 connected friends, spouses, and siblings from the Framingham Heart Study in the year 2000. Each node represents a person, and its shape indicates gender (circles are female; squares are male). Lines between nodes indicate relationships (black for siblings, red for friends and spouses). Node color indicates how happy each person is, with blue shades indicating the least happy, and yellow shades the most happy; shades of green are intermediate. Unhappy people and happy people tend to cluster in separate groups. In addition, unhappy people are more likely to be at the periphery of the network.

Network Science

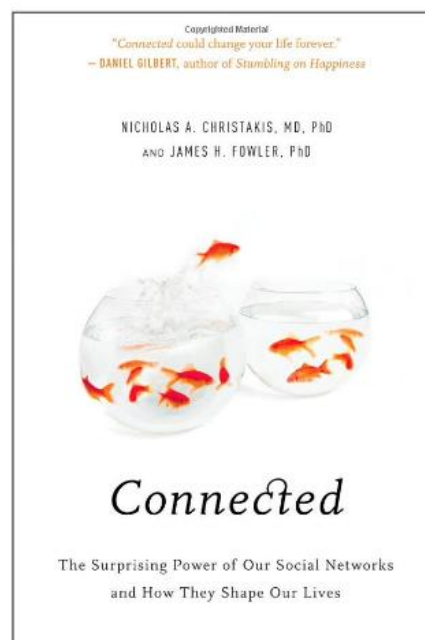
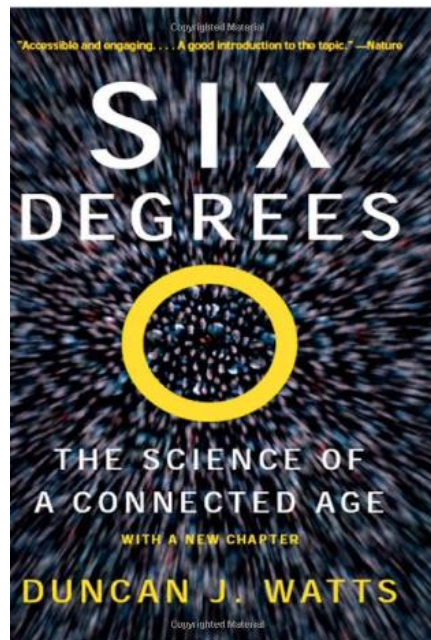
- Albert-László Barabási (<https://barabasi.com/book/>)



- Martin Grandjean (<http://www.martingrandjean.ch>)



Cărți traduse în peste 20 de limbi



Social networks theories

GRANOVETTER, Mark (1973) : *The strenght of weak ties*

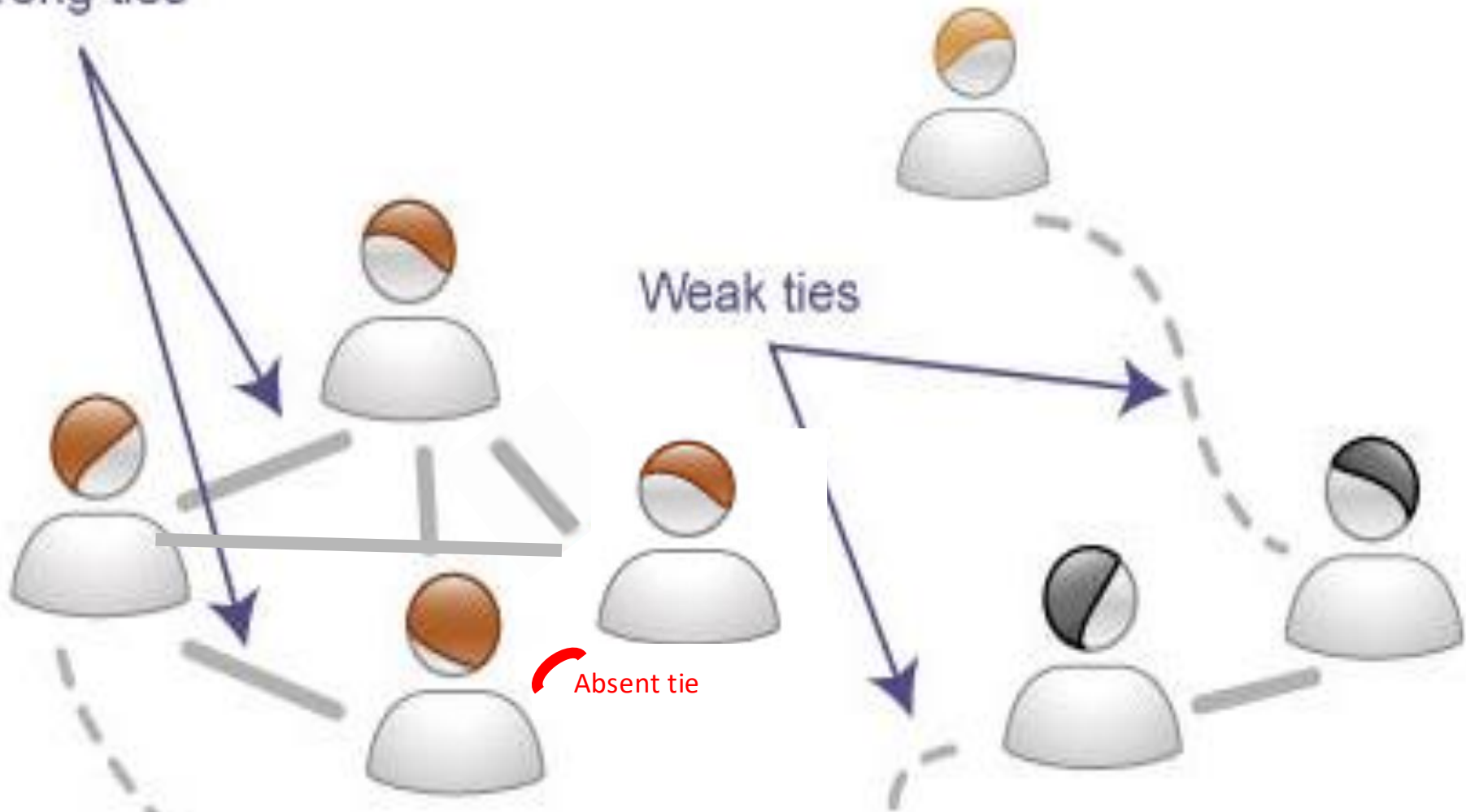
- Any positive and symmetrical social tie can be evaluated according to its strength, which depends on:
 - Time invested
 - Mutual trust (privacy)
 - Emotional intensity
 - Degree of reciprocity
- **Strong ties** : A and B spend a lot of time together, trust each other, get emotionally involved and do each other favours.
- **Weak ties** : A and B rarely interact, little trust in each other, low emotional involvement
- **Absent ties** : Non-existent and insignificant - A has interacted with B little in some context

Strong ties

Weak ties

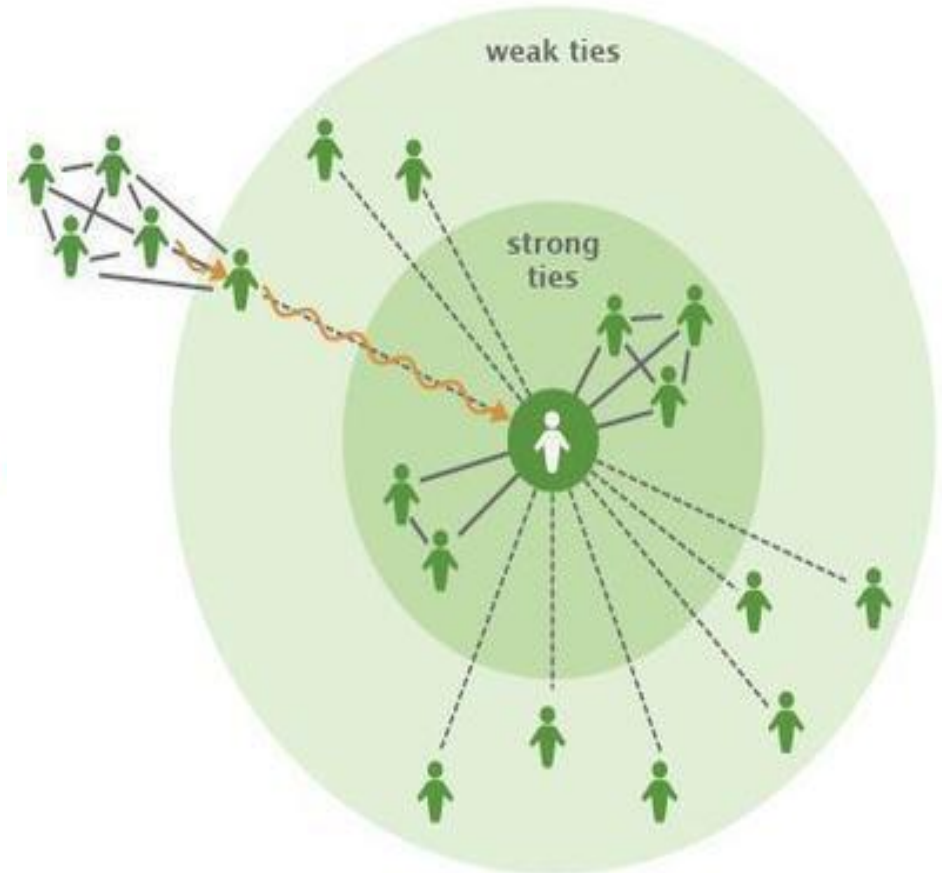
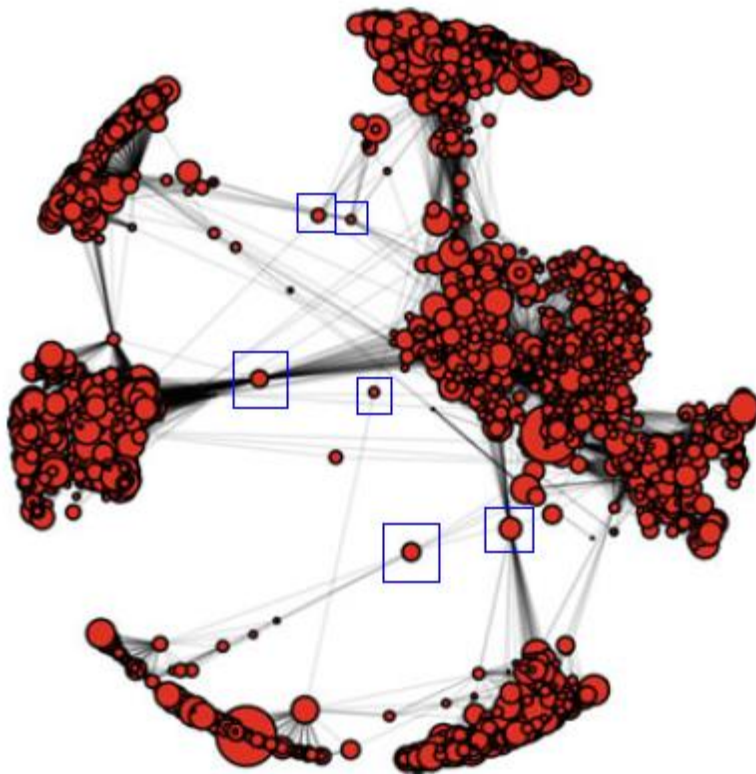
Absent tie

Strong, weak, absent ties





<https://youtu.be/g3bBajcR5fE>



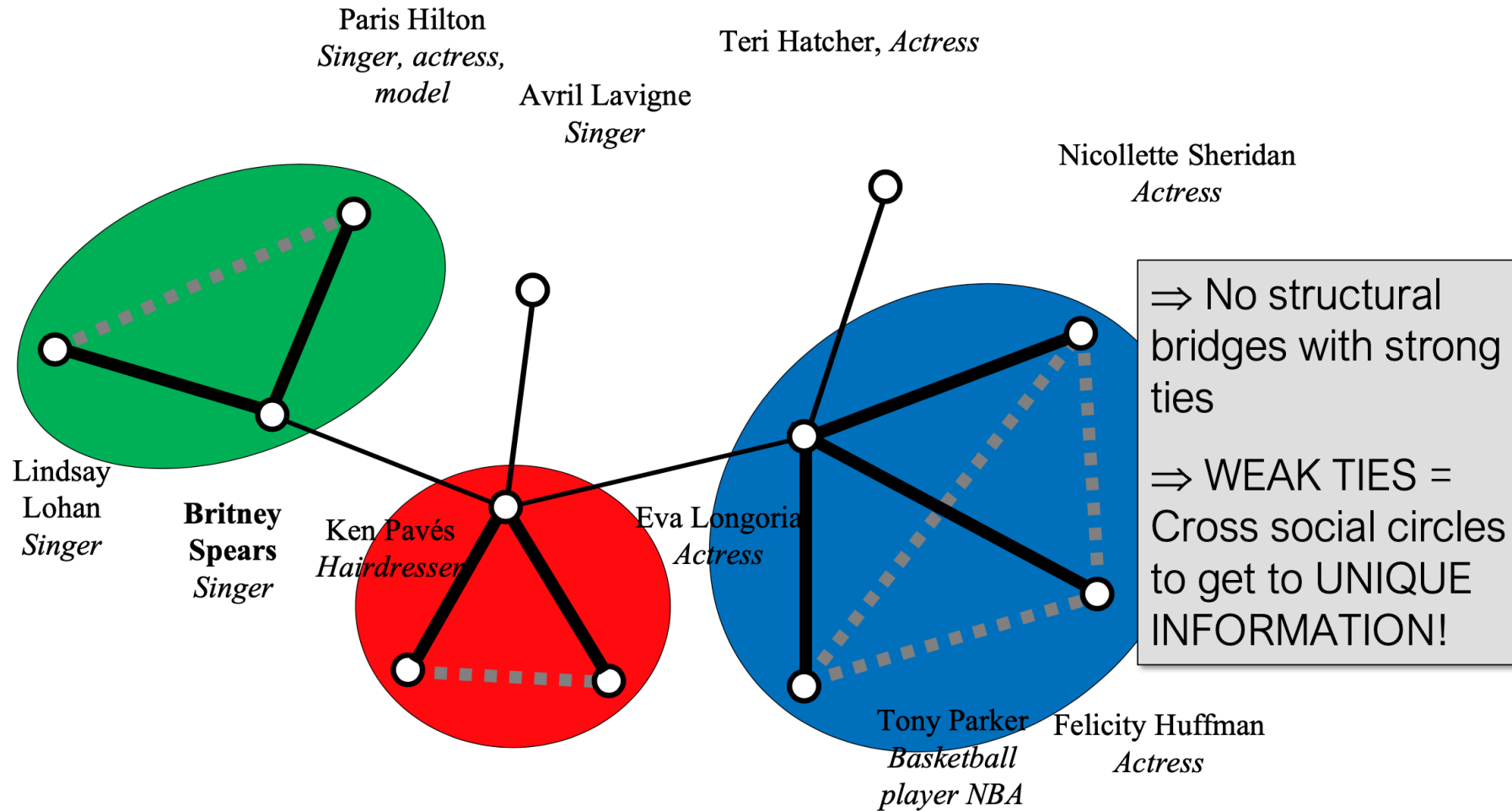
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Granovetter's study - The Influence of Social Ties on Occupational Mobility
(see Granovetter, 1983- supplementary bibliography)

The Strength of Weak Ties

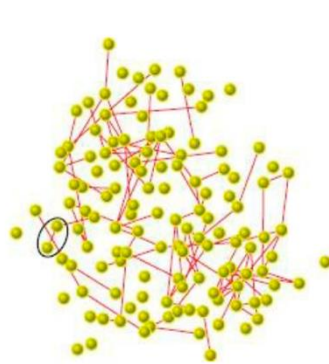
- Homophily (similarity): individuals prefer to interact with similar alters
 - Cognitive balance: alters with whom an ego has strong ties will, in turn, develop positive ties with each other...if not strong, at least weak.
 - **Bridge** ties: between pairs of nodes that would otherwise be far apart (Granovetter demonstrates that these are most likely weak ties).
 - Actor A's bridges allow ties to nodes to which A's friends have no ties - they allow access to new information
- Weak ties are much more likely to provide new information and are surprisingly strong
- Weak ties give individuals access to information and resources other than those available in their social circle or neighbourhood.
- **Another of Granovetter's concepts, developed based on social relationships and networks and their importance in the economy, is embeddedness:** <https://youtu.be/KXGbCjzmm2M>
- the degree of involvement of an 'entity' in a social network

Example created by Filip Agneessens, Associate Professor at Surrey Business School, University of Surrey (2019, Research in Social Sciences Summer School)

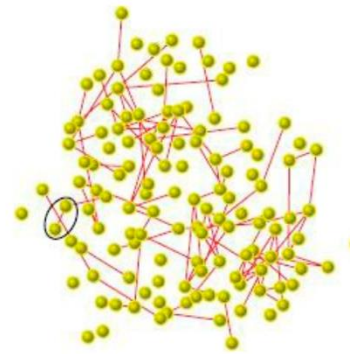


Information is spread over social circles via WEAK ties

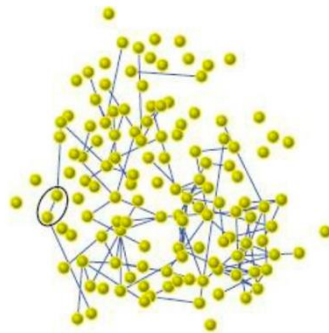
Source: Christakis &
Fowler (2009, p. 297)



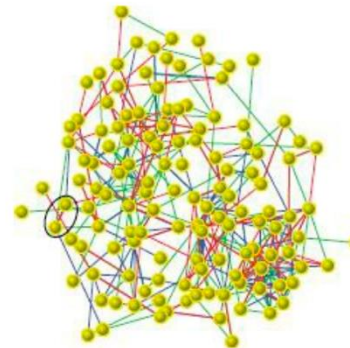
Friendship network



Coworker network



Sexual-contact network



All networks combined

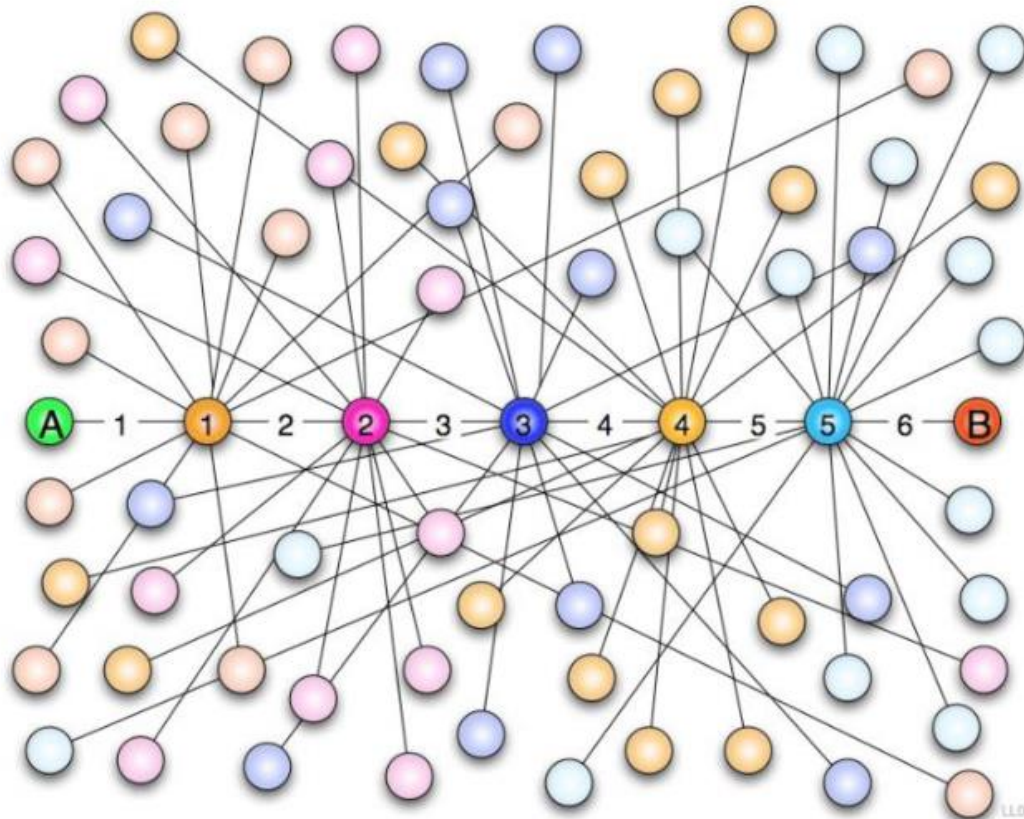
Plate 2. Different kinds of networks can overlap as shown here in a hypothetical network of 130 people. The network of friends (top left) is also the primary source of potential partners in the sexual-contact network (top right). Other networks, like those on the job (bottom left), also may be a source for friendship and potential sexual partners. The bottom-right network is multiplex, with several different kinds of relationships combining to contribute to the full social network. Some people have multiplex relationships with one another (for example, two people could be friends, coworkers, *and* sexual partners as indicated by the circled pair).

The Small World Problem

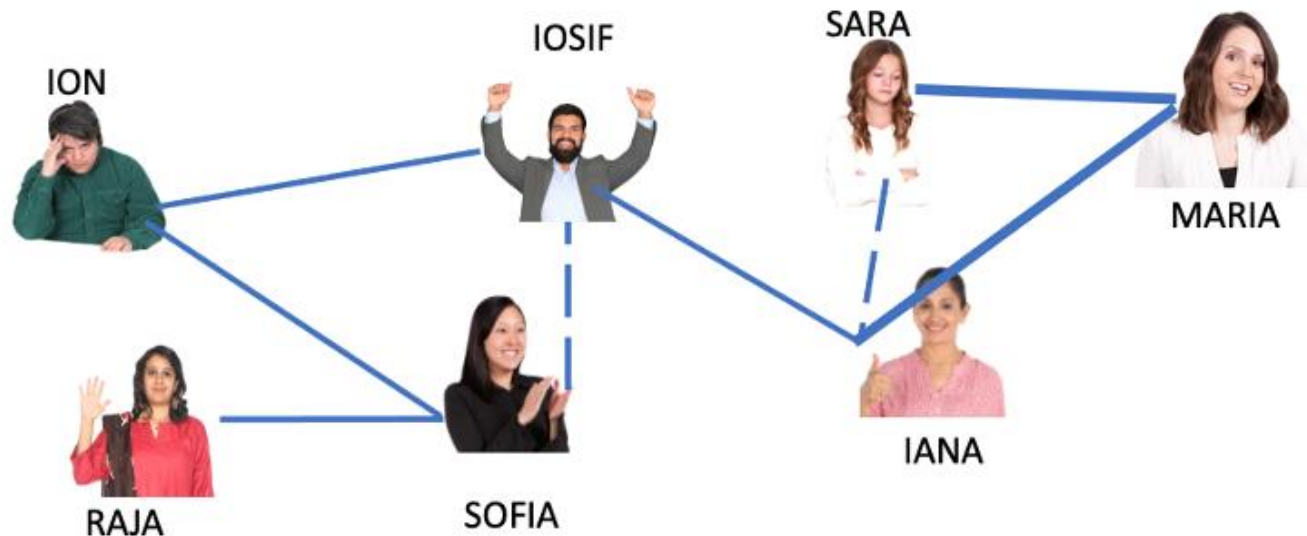
Milgram, Stanley (1967): the probability of any 2 people to know each other

- Two approaches on society and the world:
 1. Any two people in the world, no matter where they are located, can be connected by acquaintances or ties, and the number of these acquaintances is quite small
 2. The world is a collection of groups or social circles that any bridging ties cannot connect - his example was related to a message that can circulate in one circle of acquaintances but can never pass into another circle of acquaintances.
- Milgram Experiment : <https://youtu.be/NRWSF1c0Ez0>
- Six ties between any two people: <https://youtu.be/TcxZSmzPw8k>
- Kevin Bacon's game, the distance of any American actor from his fellow Kevin Bacon: <https://youtu.be/n9u-TITxwoM>

Six degrees of separation



- The idea of the six degrees of separation is that: two individuals, anywhere in the world, can be connected by a chain of six or fewer acquaintances.



→ This means that while Ion doesn't know Maria, she knows Iosif, who knows Iana, who knows Maria. Thus, Ion is three intermediaries away or three degrees of separation.

→ the distance between any two nodes in a network is unexpectedly small → "we live in a small world".

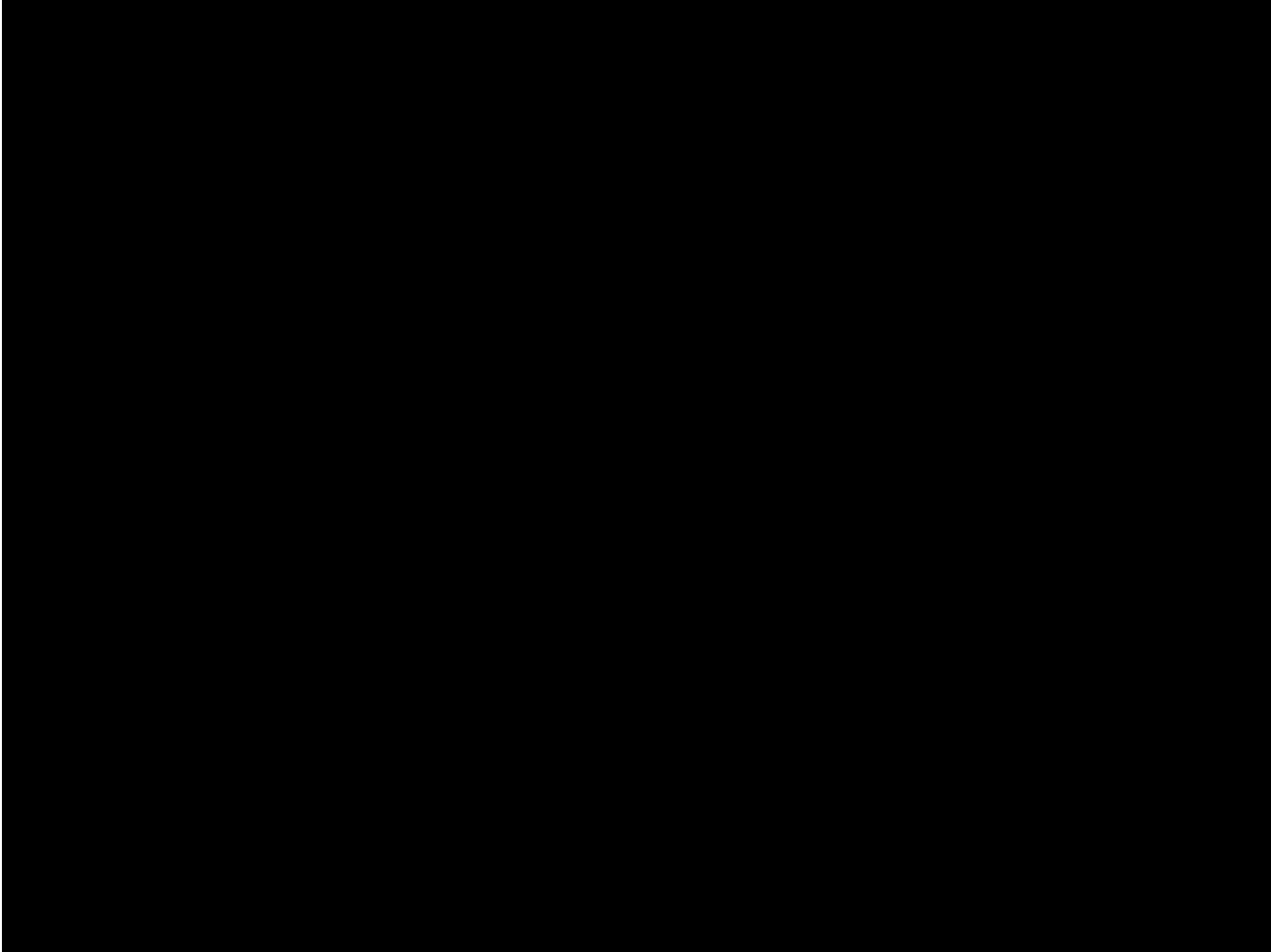


Pioneers

- 1929 - Karinty publishes "The Chains"
- Erdős and Rény's random network theory (1959)

Lanțul slăbiciunilor- I.L. Caragiale (1952)

The Chain of weaknesses- Romanian literature



https://youtu.be/Vd9_5pVT09E?si=TDCaESyXz91XQsrV

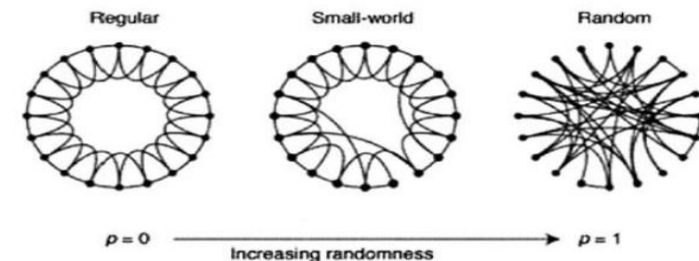
Separation degrees of the ...
mathematicians
Hollywood actors
clusters

Erdős number - the distance between any two mathematicians by Paul Erdős <https://youtu.be/izdZPx89ph4>

The Kevin Bacon game - the distance any Hollywood actor is from Bacon <https://youtu.be/vOUdy2l0IfU>

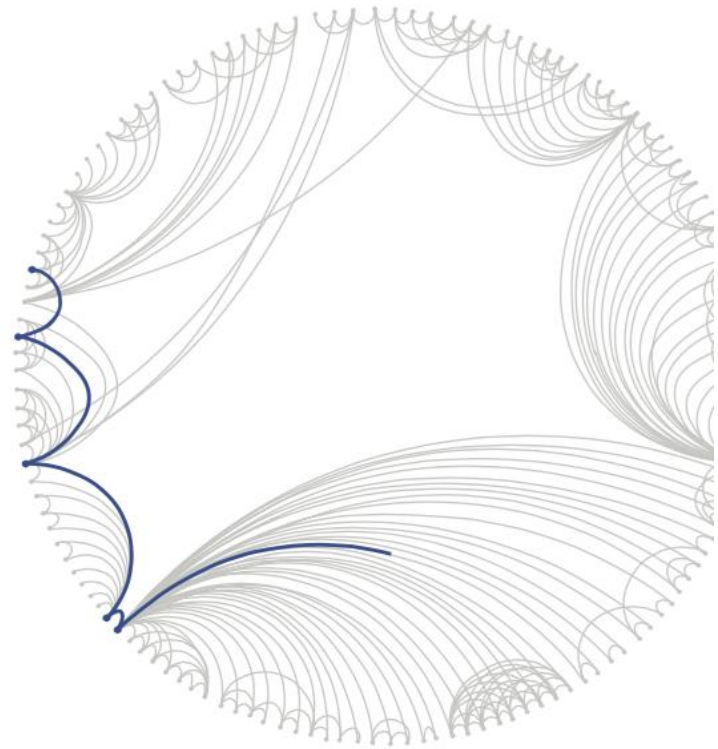
Barabasi and Jeong: the nineteen degrees of separation of the (www) <https://youtu.be/qmCrtuS9vtU>
<https://youtu.be/RfgjHoVCZwU?si=DyXaaJqFaq9W2H8c>

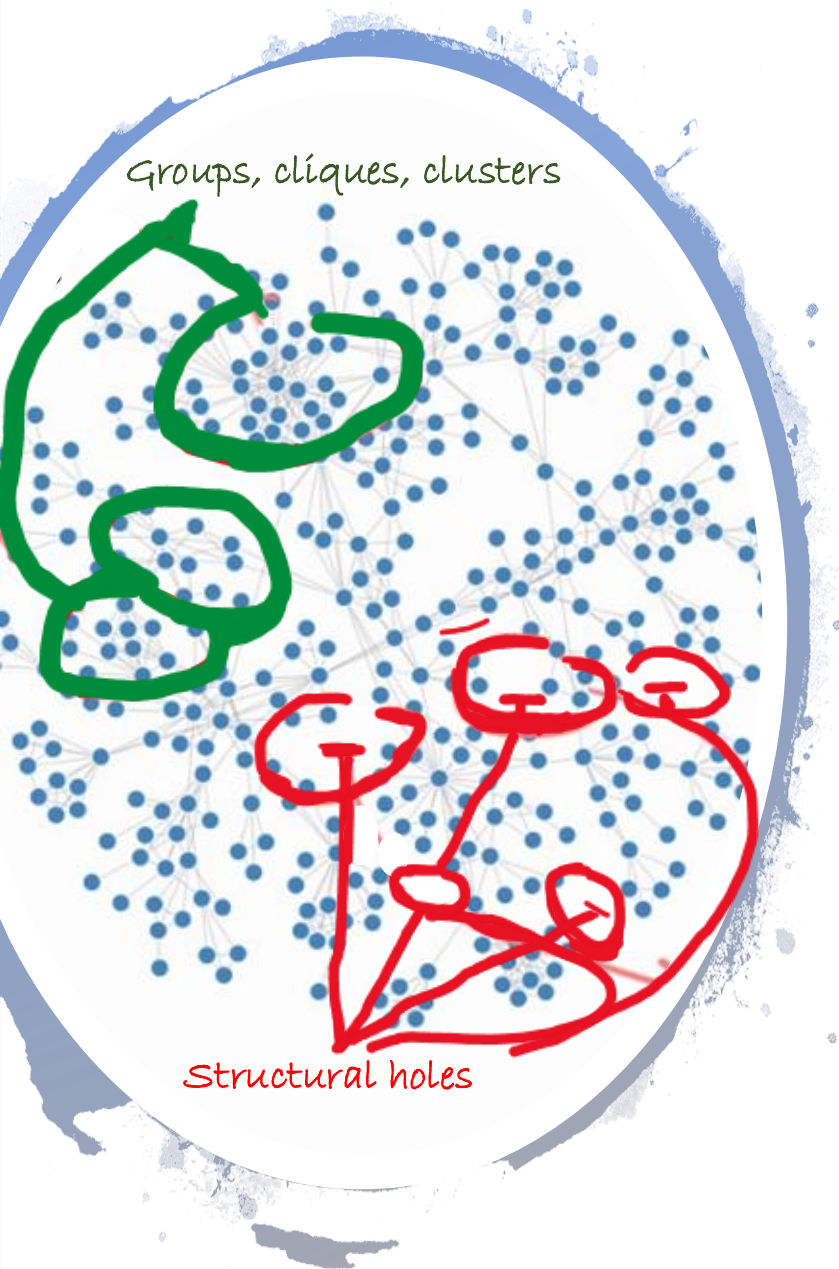
Watts & Stogartz (1998): crowding goes beyond social
networking - remote connections <https://youtu.be/QUWds9gt6aE>



3.5 degrees of separation on Facebook

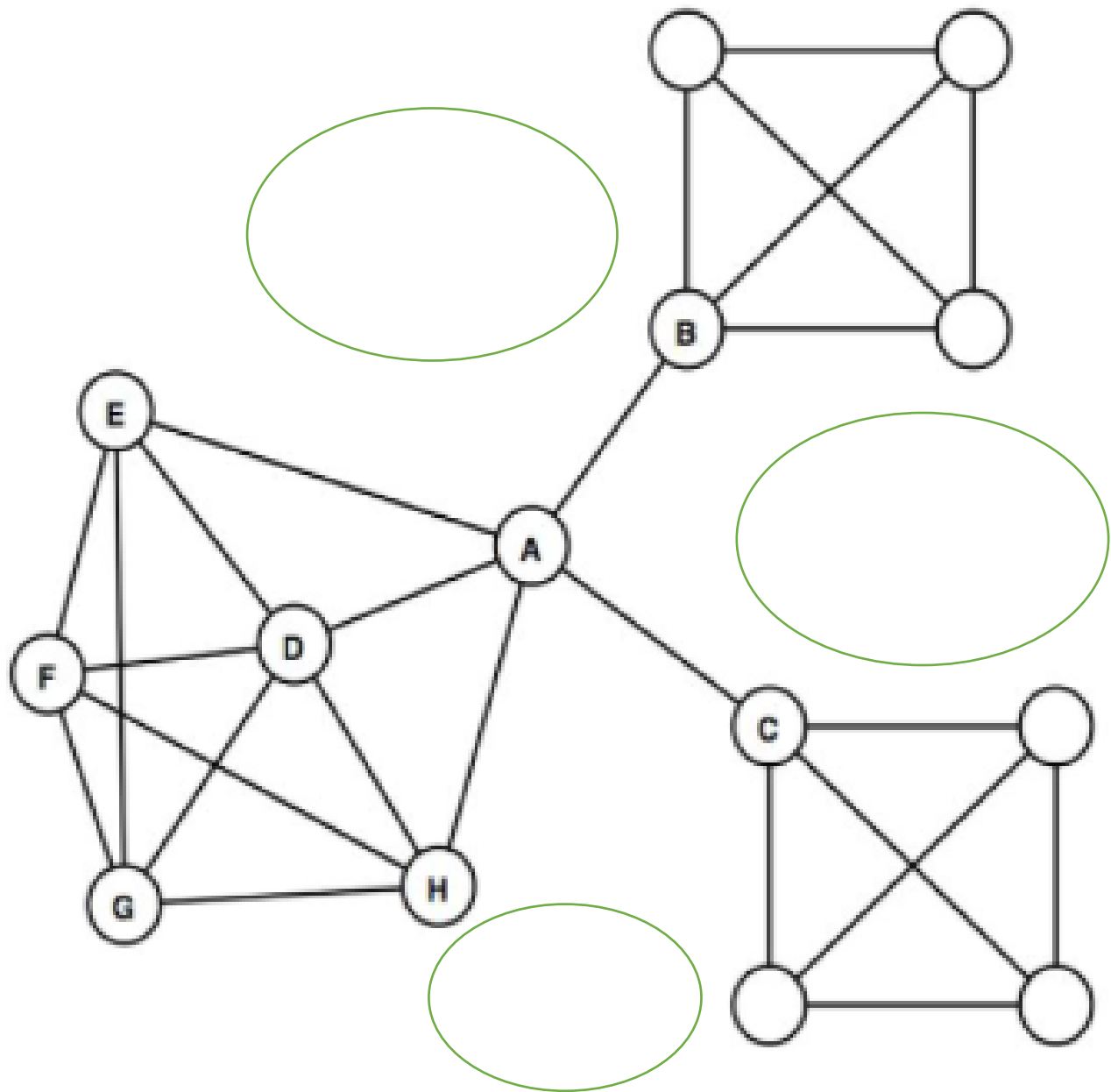
- <https://research.facebook.com/blog/2016/2/three-and-a-half-degrees-of-separation/>





Structural hole theory(Burt,1992, 2000, 2010)

- In general, not all possible connections exist between members of a network, a phenomenon known as structural holes. Better connected individuals are more informed and influential, but they are also more subject to influence from others.
- There are homogeneous networks in terms of the degree of connectedness of nodes and others where there is a small elite of centrally located and well-connected individuals alongside a large mass of relatively isolated actors. Differences in the degree of connectedness are relevant to the order and hierarchy within the group.



01

Within a network, there are groups and sub-groups that communicate more intensively with each other than with the rest of the network

- Dyads
- triads
- small groups

02

Structural holes indicate how actors are grouped in neighbourhoods—when there is a structural hole between A and B, exchanges between the two cannot be carried out because they are either unaware of each other or have high transaction costs.

Thus, another actor C who has a tie to both actor A and actor B has the advantage of influencing exchanges or choosing between the two

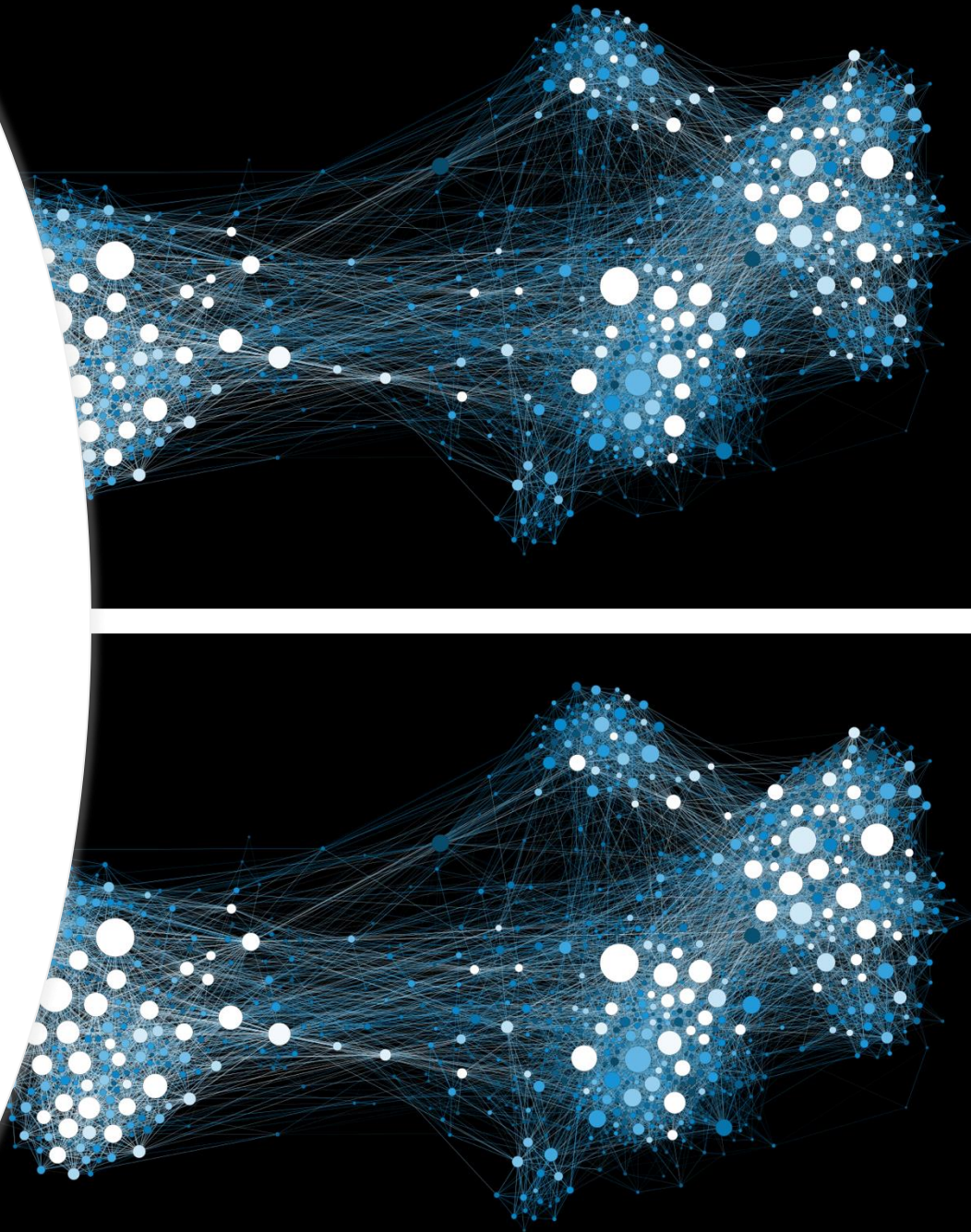
03

Within one group, individuals who can provide bridges between distinct groups within the network are more important for network communication than individuals with multiple ties.

Tertius gaudens (Simmel, 1950)

is the person who gains an advantage from the division of two other actors and is defined as "the third one who wins".

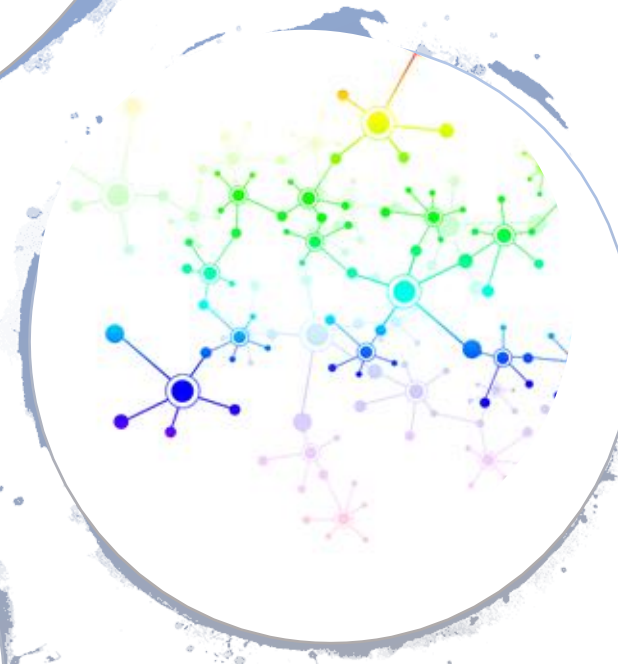
- An individual dealing with a structural hole is in control by having the power to negotiate the relationship between two actors divided by that hole.
- The power of structural holes is given by the opportunity to control and negotiate the relationship between the two actors who have valuable information, which highlights the theory's relevance for Internet networks.
- Burt (2000, p. 355) observed that accurate, ambiguous, or distorted information strategically transmitted between contacts by the "tertius" can turn into informational strategies in which information is altered or suppressed to distance „alters“ or create conflict.



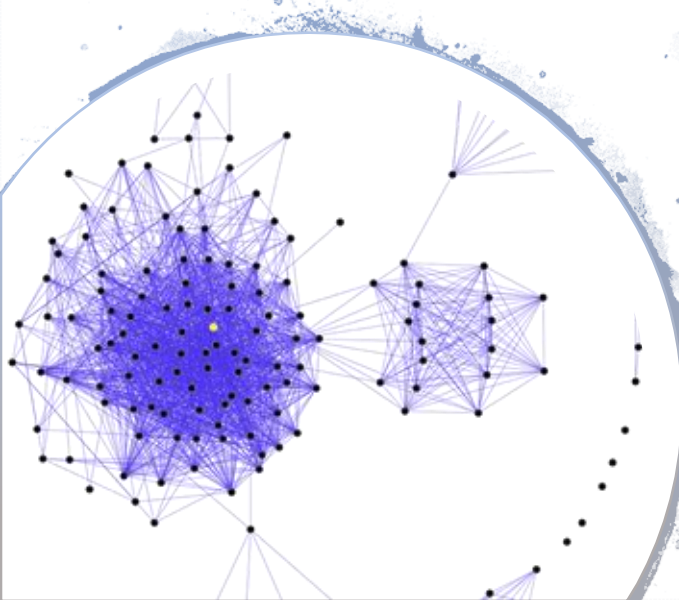


- ***Tertius iungens*** intermediation may involve the desire to create or build a network by combining resources or by including and connecting certain nodes, but it may also involve simultaneously excluding other nodes or enhancing the reputation of the intermediary node by creating valuable introductions (with other nodes).

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The broker can exploit his alters by introducing them to valuable nodes or by determining gaudens-like orientations to keep competitors or combatants at bay.



- *Tertius iungens's* activities can generate selfish inclinations, oriented towards individual well-being, which can harm the network.
- See: <https://youtu.be/II0ED28rf54>

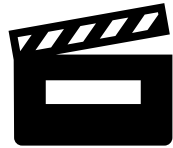
The theory of structural holes (Burt, 1992)

- Burt, 1992: there are two types of benefits from structural holes in networks: **information** and **control**
- **INFORMATION** (structural gaps lead to informational benefits for actors inside and outside the network because they bring a new input of information - unknown to one of the parties → The connected individuals are more informed but also more subject to the influences of those around them)
 - actors with access to diverse information can make better use of it
 - actors with solid connections are the first to know important information.
 - actors who manage structural holes in a network enjoy higher rates of return on their investments, know the context better, and get more profitable opportunities.
- **CONTROL** (the advantages of being a key player in a well-connected network)
 - Well-connected central actors to various mutually unconnected groups have more bargaining opportunities than peripheral ones, so they can control most of the information flows within the network.

The theory of structural holes(Burt,1992, 2000, 2011)

- Burt (1992, 2000, 2010): the benefits an individual derives from their network (ego-network) of contacts vary according to :
 - Size (number of ties): the more alters an ego has, the greater the chance that one of the alters has the resources the ego needs.
 - Density: an ego is much more advantaged if the density of links between alters is lower (the chances of obtaining non-redundant information increase) -(Burt, 2000)
 - Heterogeneity: various alters (gender, age, race, occupation, functions, skills, etc.)
 - Compositional quality: the number of alters who hold high levels of resources that the ego needs. The more connected an ego is to the alters they need, the more social capital they are expected to have.

See: <https://youtu.be/GaQLRCaLQG4>



<https://youtu.be/VngfnLGRy5Y>

Burt, 2015:



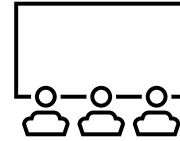
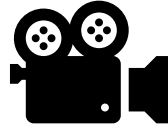


Theories concerning the consequences of social networks

- Individuals in the network end up developing common values, beliefs, attitudes, behaviours, and practices: CONTAGION– Burt (1987)
- Influence increases more in networks with higher cohesiveness than in those with lower cohesiveness
- Actors occupying similar positions in the network usually share common characteristics - same social status, same behavioural traits

**Physical proximity → Social proximity
(friendship) → Common attitudes**

- The more frequent and empathetic the interaction between A and B, the more likely B is to adopt an attitude, belief, etc. that A has adopted.



- Social networks influence Nicholas Christakis (TED Talks)- (optional /supplementary)
 - https://www.ted.com/talks/nicholas_christakis_the_hidden_influence_of_social_networks/footnotes#t-54396
 - https://www.ted.com/talks/nicholas_christakis_how_social_networks_predict_epidemics#t-109721
- Studies:
 - Fowler, James H. și Christakis, Nicholas A., 2008. “Dynamic spread of happiness in a large social network: longitudinal analysis over 20 years in the Framingham Heart Study” - see <http://nrs.harvard.edu/urn-3:HUL.InstRepos:3685822> (optional /supplementary)
 - Nicholas A. Christakis și Fowler, James H. 2007, The Spread of Obesity in a Large Social Network over 32 Years (optional /supplementary)- see <https://www.nejm.org/doi/full/10.1056/NEJMs066082>

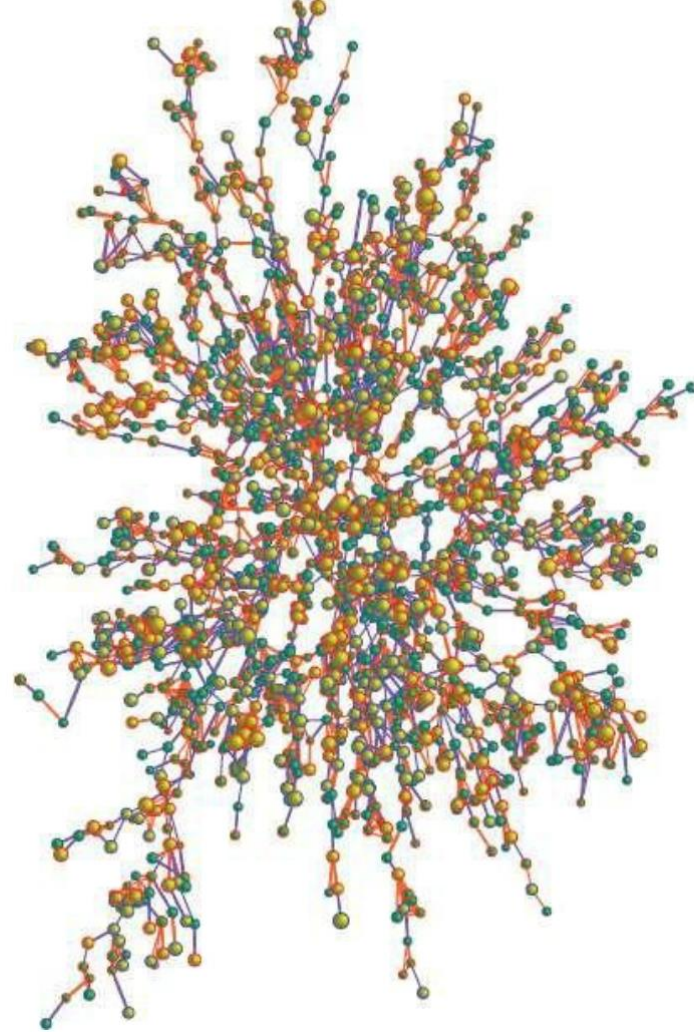


Plate 3. A network of 2,200 people from the Framingham Heart Study in the year 2000. Node borders indicate gender (red for female, blue for male); node colors indicate obesity (yellow for body mass index [BMI] of 30 or more, green for BMI less than 30); node sizes are proportional to BMI; and tie colors indicate the kind of relationship (purple for friend or spouse, orange for family). Clustering of obese and nonobese individuals can be observed within particular locations in the network.

Source: Christakis &
Fowler (2009, p. 299)

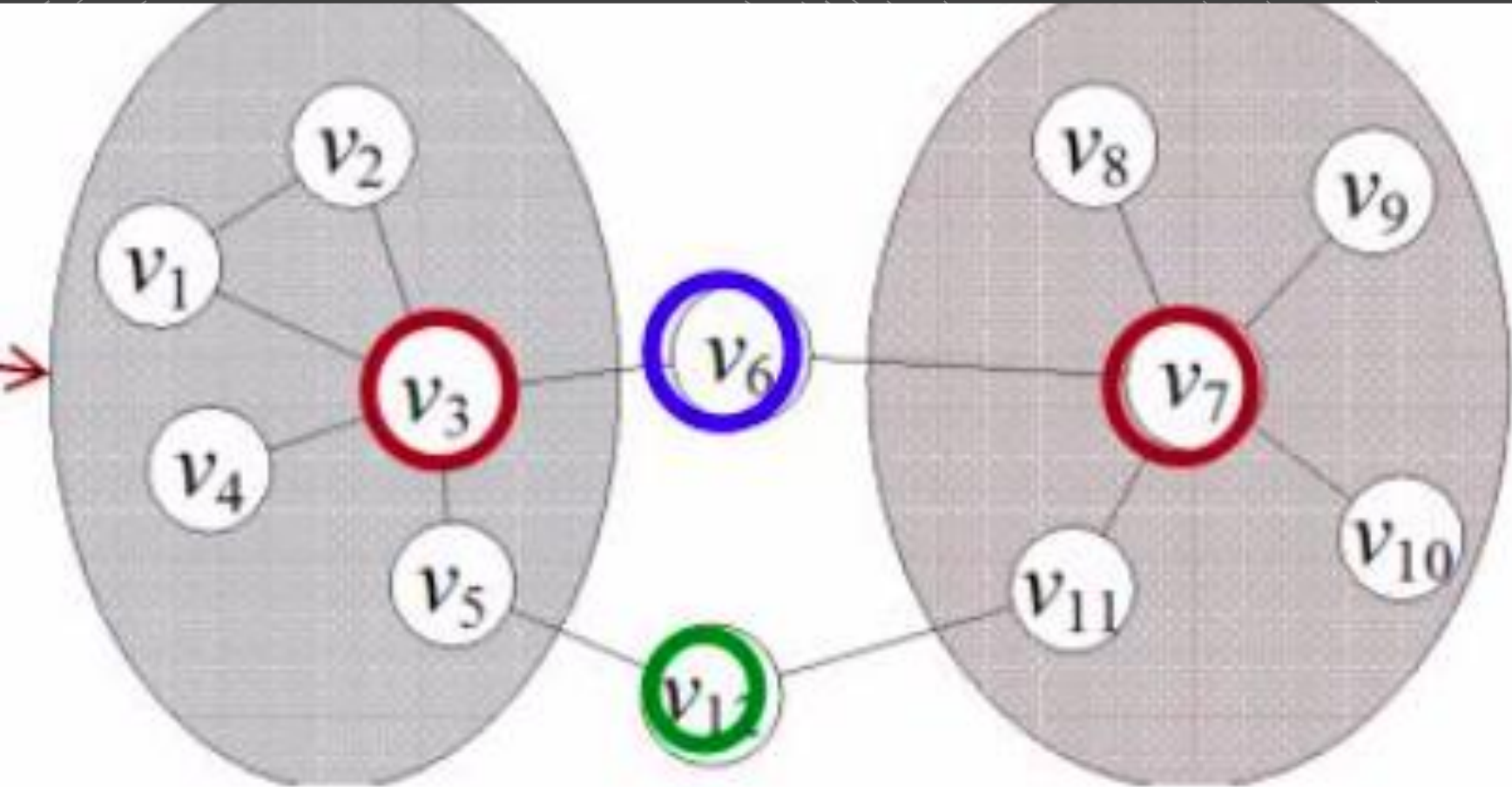
Information sharing on social networks

Burt (1999) argues that there are two (2) mechanisms of sharing information within a network:

- through a two-step communication flow: opinion leaders disseminate information to the group
- contagion → through structural equivalence that generates adoption of behaviour within the group

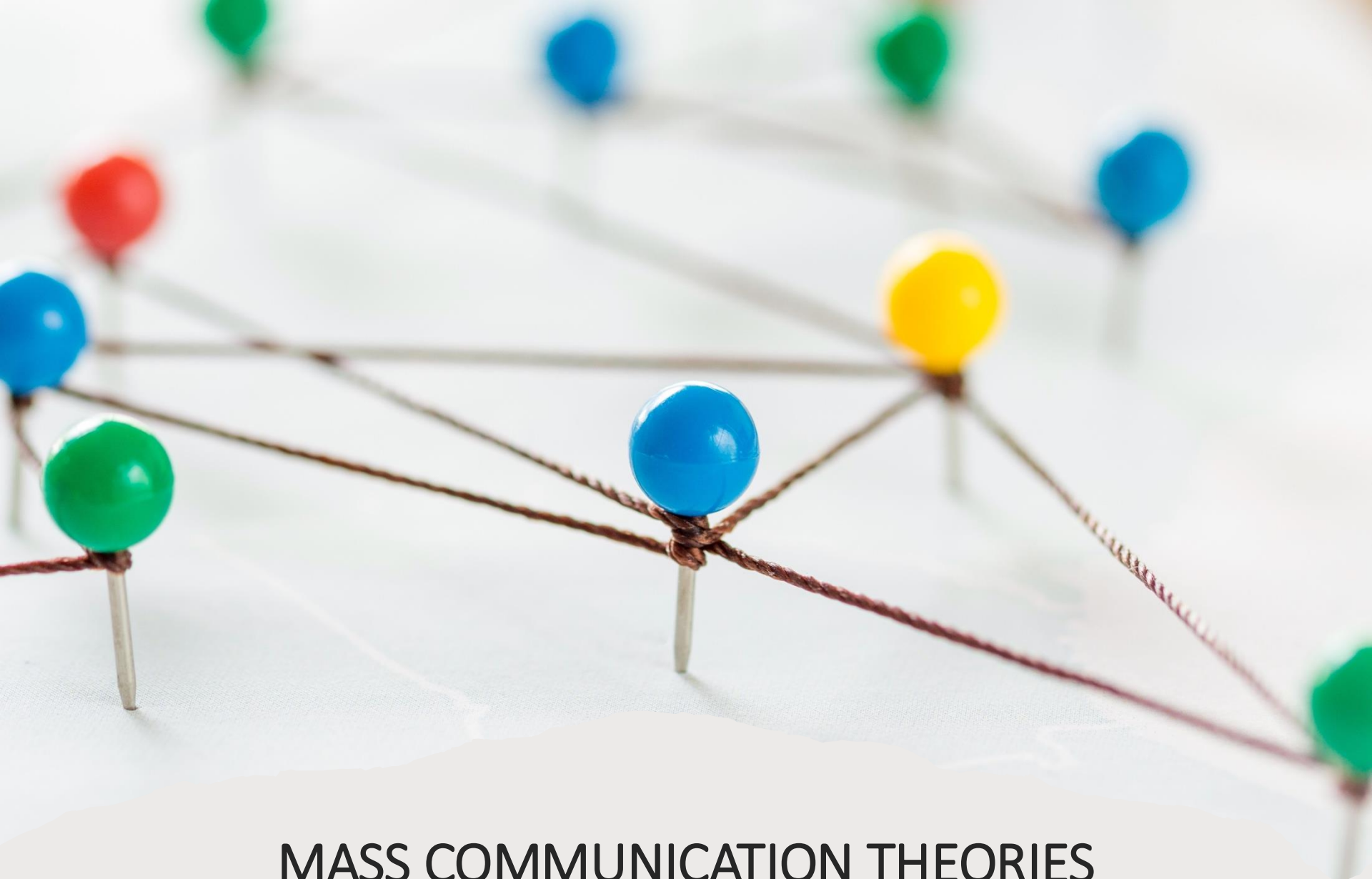
OPINION LEADERS on the network - network centrality

- - Individuals with a high degree of centrality in the network are likely to be opinion leaders of the network
- - Individuals with a high degree of "connectivity" (betweenness) serve as bridges; nodes that link clusters - GATEKEEPERS
- - Structural hole spanners are more likely to connect the most important nodes (opinion leaders)



- SOURCE: Lou și Tang (2013) – <http://keg.cs.tsinghua.edu.cn/jietang/publications/WWW13-Lou&Tang-Structural-Hole-Information-Diffusion.pdf> , accessed October 2023;

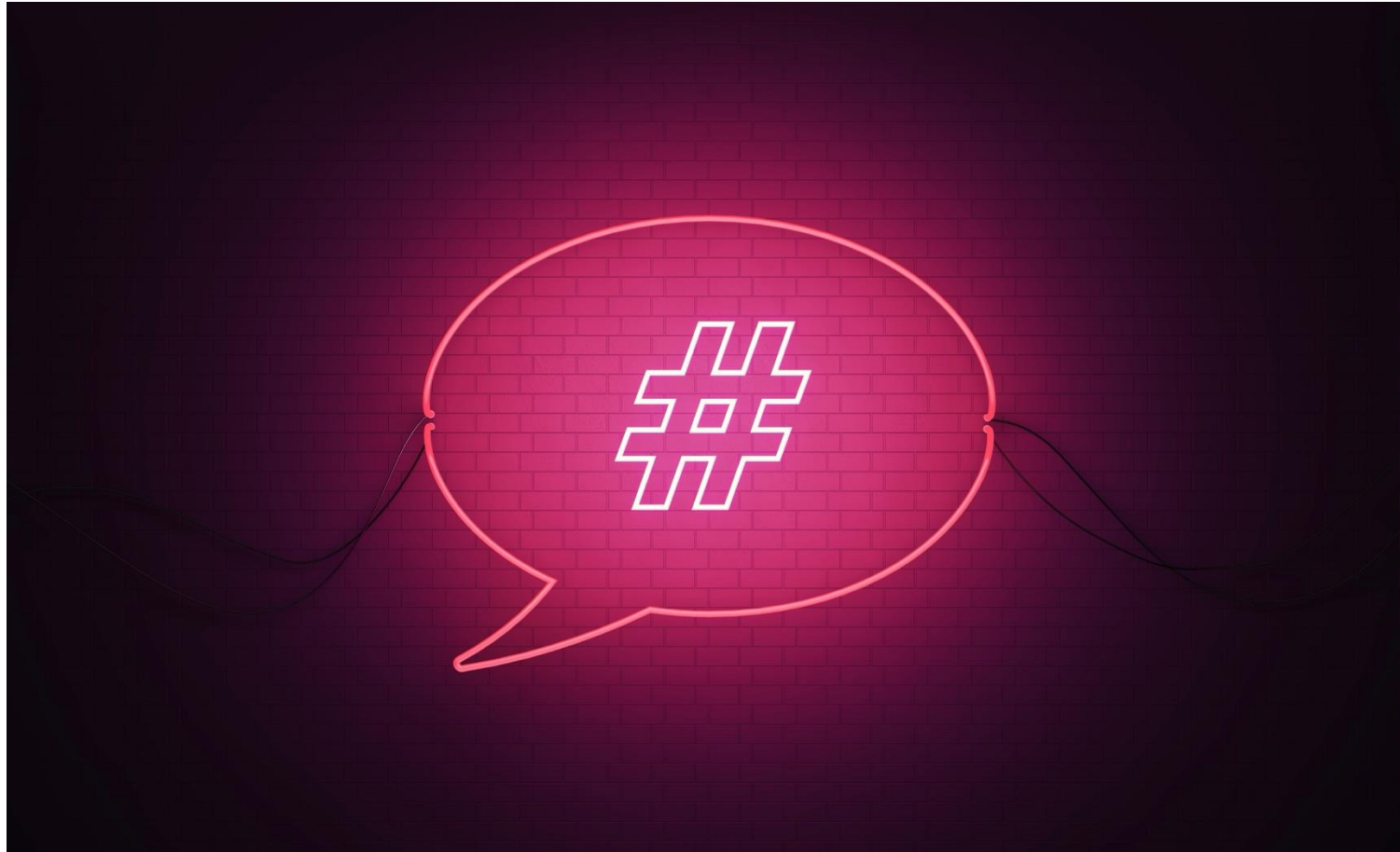
- Opinion leaders control the flow of information within the community; whereas
- Structural Hole Connections dominate the distribution of information between communities

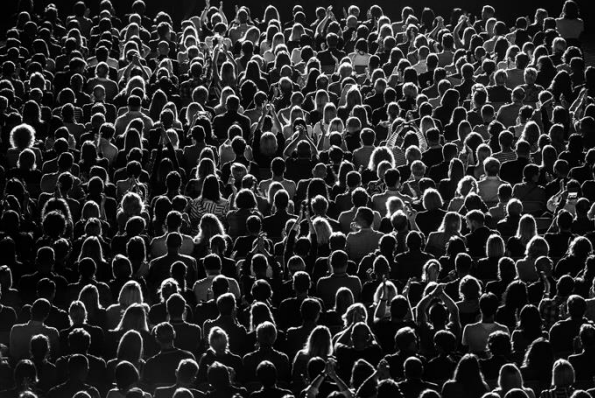


MASS COMMUNICATION THEORIES

Media theories

„Media is the message” (McLuhan, 1964)





Media – Mass communication

- Media – plural *medium* → *communication channel*
 - from print to digital data, including various forms of information.
 - Anything that can reach or influence people, including telephones, television and the internet, can be considered a form of media.
- Mass communication: the process by which a complex entity produces and broadcasts, through one or multiple devices, public messages to a huge, heterogeneous and dispersed audience.
- It involves encoding and decoding in several stages
- Noise: semantic, background and machine noise



The defining features of classic mass communication(Dominick, 2009, p. 16)

- Complex and formalised organisations produce mass communication
- Mass communication organisations have several gatekeepers
- Mass communication organisations need large amounts of money to operate
- Mass communication organisations exist to make a profit
- Mass communication organisations are highly competitive

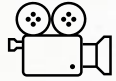
Do these still apply to the current media context governed by Social Media platforms?

Early theories in media studies

- Hypodermic needle or magic bullet theory or the described tape theory (propaganda)
- Two- or n-step communication model
- Gatekeeping theory



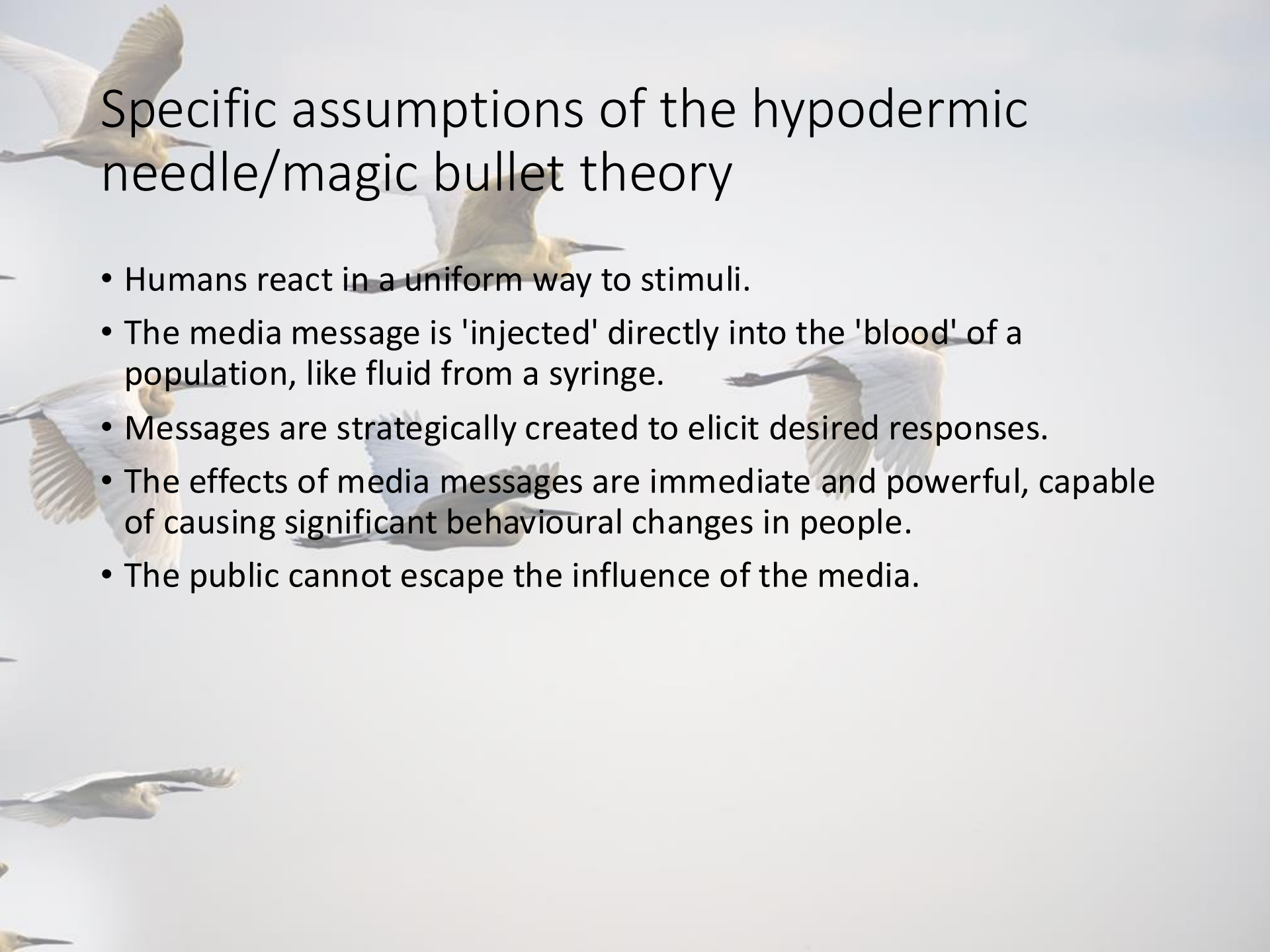
Magic bullet theory



<https://youtu.be/Qt5MjBlvGcY>



- Assumption: The media has a direct, immediate, and consequent effect on its audience.
- A media message is "injected" entirely into the audience's consciousness (which is passive) and is wholly accepted.
- The media message is a bullet fired from the 'media gun' into the 'head' of the audience.
- Harold Lasswell proposed the magic bullet theory after the First World War. As radio, films, and commercials gained massive popularity between the 1930s and 1950s, the effects of the media on people's behaviour seemed obvious.
- Factors:
 - The emergence and popularisation of radio and television.
 - The emergence of persuasive industries such as advertising and propaganda.
 - The Payne Fund studies of the 1930s looked at the impact of cinema films on children
 - Hitler's monopolisation of the media during World War II to unite the German public behind the Nazi party.
- To the casual observer, people seemed truly powerless to resist the messages coming from the media. For the first time, messages were crafted for a target audience to elicit specific responses.



Specific assumptions of the hypodermic needle/magic bullet theory

- Humans react in a uniform way to stimuli.
- The media message is 'injected' directly into the 'blood' of a population, like fluid from a syringe.
- Messages are strategically created to elicit desired responses.
- The effects of media messages are immediate and powerful, capable of causing significant behavioural changes in people.
- The public cannot escape the influence of the media.

Gatekeeping theory

Assumptions: gatekeepers are, at a high level, the data makers who control the flow of information to an entire social system. Based on personal preferences, professional experience, social influences or biases, they allow certain information to flow to their audience.



- Lewin (1947, 1951), the creator of the concept, analysed gatekeepers from a psychological perspective, investigating how and why families' eating habits and activities differ. In the groups he examined, he observed that housewives controlled decision-making about eating habits and activities by creating behavioural barriers and incentives; Lewin referred to these housewives as gatekeepers.
- Gatekeeping is selecting and filtering the media content that can be consumed in the time and space available to an individual. This means that gatekeeping falls into a surveillance and monitoring role. These gatekeeping decisions are made daily to select the relevant items the audience will see.
- The gatekeeper decides what information should pass through it (through the information "gate") to the group or individuals beyond and what information should not.

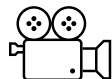
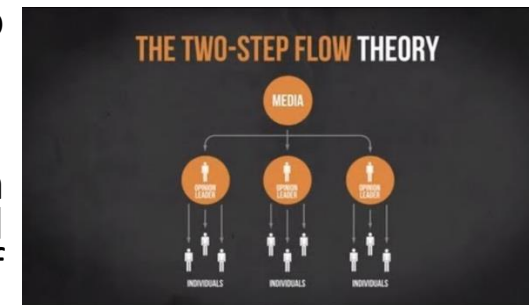
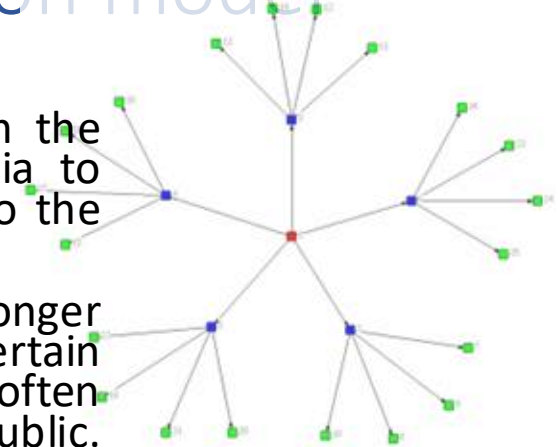
Limited effects theory

- The theory of limited effects was proposed by sociologist Paul Lazarsfeld.
- Assumption: even if the media affects individuals' thoughts and opinions, this effect is minimal or limited at best.
- The theory was developed in response to the magic bullet/hypodermic needle theory, which emphasised the powerful influence of the media.
- Lazarsfeld believes elites and the highly educated are the primary gatekeepers and consumers of media, whose biases affect how and what information is redistributed among those who consume media at much lower levels.
- Opinion leaders have mitigated or mitigated media effects by discussing and interpreting media messages with their peers.
- By the time they reach adulthood, people have their own perceptions and opinions that are independent of the media. Therefore, their peers and social institutions in general influence people more. The influence of opinion leaders, in particular, far exceeds that of the media.



The two-step flow of communication model

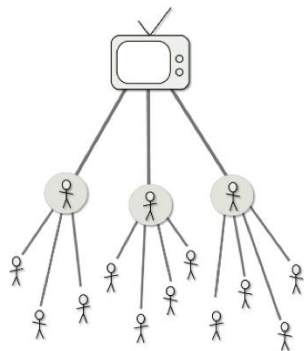
- suggests that the flow of information and influence from the media to the public involves two stages: from the media to specific individuals (e.g. opinion leaders) and from them to the public.
- General assumption: Interpersonal communication has a stronger impact on individual attitudes than the media itself → Certain individuals are more central and influential in their groups, often acting as intermediaries between the media and the public. Compared to the rest of the population, these individuals were found to be more exposed to the media.
- Thus, if personal influence was so important, and if it was mainly executed by certain individuals who were more exposed to the media than the people they influenced, then it could be assumed that there was a two-stage flow process from the media to opinion leaders and from them to their followers.
- The concept of a "two-step flow of communication" arose from The People's Choice, a 1948 American polling study by Paul Lazarsfeld and his colleagues at Columbia University's Office of Applied Social Research.



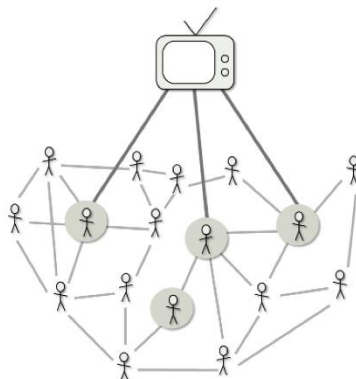
N steps flow of communication

- The first change to the two-step flow of communication was the introduction of the more-than-two-step flow.
- This allowed the inclusion of other optional flow directions such as :
 - horizontal (between leaders, between followers) and vertical (from leaders to followers, from active to inactive);
 - direct (linking two actors directly) and indirect (linking actors through a third party or a chain of intermediaries);
 - top-down (from leaders to followers, from the media to the public) and bottom-up (from opinion leaders to the media, from followers to influencers, from the marginal to the central).

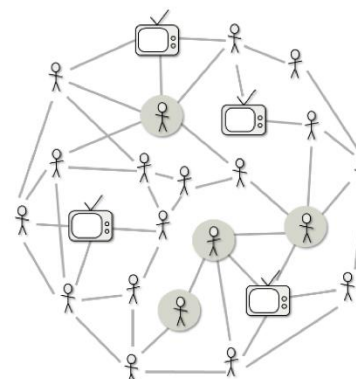
Classic two-step flow model
(Katz & Lazarsfeld)



Multistep flow network model
Type I



Multistep flow network model
Type II



See: Ognyanova, K. (2017).
„Multistep flow of communication:
Network effects”
<https://kateto.net/wp-content/uploads/2018/05/Multistep%20Flow%20of%20Communication,%20Network%20Effects%20%5BP reprint%5D%20-%20Ognyanova%20-%202017.pdf>



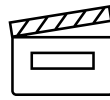
Cultivation theory

Assumptions: The media generally presents a picture of the world that does not reflect reality. Television images are an exaggeration or fantasy of what exists in reality.

People who watch TV frequently are more likely to be influenced by the messages in the audiovisual universe.

- The influence goes so far that people's worldviews and perceptions begin to reflect what they repeatedly see and hear on TV → which contributes to how people perceive social reality.
- Television provides many ideas and conceptions about various social and cultural issues such as race, gender, sexuality, etc.
- Over time, a fixed image of different groups of people is formed, and viewers begin to absorb these ideas, which they then use as a map to navigate life.
- This constant exposure to media content cultivates specific values, beliefs, attitudes and desires in people.
- People unconsciously shape their thought processes and behaviour based on what they consume.

Media ecology



<https://youtu.be/Ko6J9v1C9zE>

- McLuhan(1964): „Media is the message” —the communication media with and through which we interact with the world are, in essence, extensions of our sensory apparatus → Each communication medium has a set of intrinsic sensory characteristics designed to enhance our ability to "feel" the world → The study of communication media is, therefore, the study of our sensory extensions.
- Media ecology concerns the effects that media generate, who is affected, how, to what extent, and why.
- Basic assumptions: The media are infiltrated into every fact and action in society. The media fix es our perceptions and organise our experiences. The media connects the world.

→ Mass media are everywhere and all the time; media determine what we know and how we feel about what we know, and media connect us with others.

To understand the effects of the symbolic medium, McLuhan divides human history into four periods: the Tribal Age, the Literacy Age, the Print Age, and the Electronic Age.

- Social media ecology → platformization
For example, with the rise of Instagram Stories/Reels, creators are faced with a new set of content creation possibilities that can be compared to their previous experiences with different platforms and how this impacts their brand subjectivities.
- The platform's infrastructure and technical characteristics affect the production, distribution, and circulation of content.
- Activities are increasingly becoming "platform dependent" (Nieborg & Poell, 2018)
→ Content circulation and visibility are subject not only to the terms and conditions of a narrow group of platforms but also to algorithmic infrastructures. Thus, content creation is 'conditioned' by platforms' distribution, analysis, and recirculation conditions (Morris, 2015).

See: <https://youtu.be/wUPKBrgxbOI>

Uses and gratification

https://youtu.be/aopqPs7rb_Q

General assumptions:

*Audiences take an active role in selecting a medium and interpreting and integrating it into their lives - Audiences have a sense of self-awareness about their motives and needs, which allows them to share their media experiences as active media users.

*Different types of media compete with each other and with other sources of satisfaction for audience attention.

*The media that provides the most satisfaction for a person will be used more often than other types.

"Uses and gratifications" focuses on:

"(1) the social and psychological origins of needs (2), which generate expectations (3) from media or other sources (4), leading to differentiated patterns of media exposure (5), leading to need gratification (6) and other consequences (7), perhaps mostly unintended" (Katz et al., 1974, p. 20).

Rubin (2002) includes seven elements in uses and gratifications: psychological and social environment, communication needs and motives, media, attitudes and expectations about media, functional alternatives to media use, communication behaviour, and outcomes or consequences of behaviour.

Uses and gratification

- Blumler and Katz (1964) identified several types of needs that motivate people to seek satisfaction in media:
 - Cognitive - Refers to the acquisition of information to aid the thinking and understanding process. People use media to develop their skills or knowledge in a particular area.
 - Affective - Refers to emotions or feelings. People use media to arouse certain emotions in themselves, such as happiness, fear or pleasure.
 - Personal Integrative - Refers to promoting one's image, reputation or status. People with this need use media, such as Facebook and YouTube, to enhance their credibility or social standing or to affirm their sense of self.
 - Social Integrative - Refers to interaction with family and friends. People use media to connect with others.
 - De-stressing - Refers to having fun and reducing stress. People use media as a means of deflection or escape from reality.
- 10 uses and satisfactions for using social media (Whiting and Williams, 2013):
 - social interaction (88%), seeking information (80%), spending time (76%), entertainment (64%), relaxation (60%), usefulness of communication (56%), expressing opinions (56%), usefulness of comfort (52%), sharing information (40%) and watching and following others (20%).



Agenda setting

Early beginnings: Trenaman and McQuail's study of the 1959 UK general election, which was published in *Television and the Political Image* (1961)



Mc. Combs and Shaw (1972) - *The Agenda-Setting Function of Mass Media* and Cobb and Elder (1971) - *The politics of agenda-building: An alternative perspective for modern democratic theory*

AGENDA SETTING FUNCTION THEORY

- DEVELOPED BY MAXWELL MCCOMBS AND DONALD SHAW
- STUDY PUBLISHED IN 1972
- MCCOMBS AND SHAW FOUND A CORRELATION BETWEEN ISSUES VOTERS BELIEVED WERE IMPORTANT AND ISSUES REPORTED PROMINENTLY IN THE MEDIA



→ The media agenda becomes the public agenda.

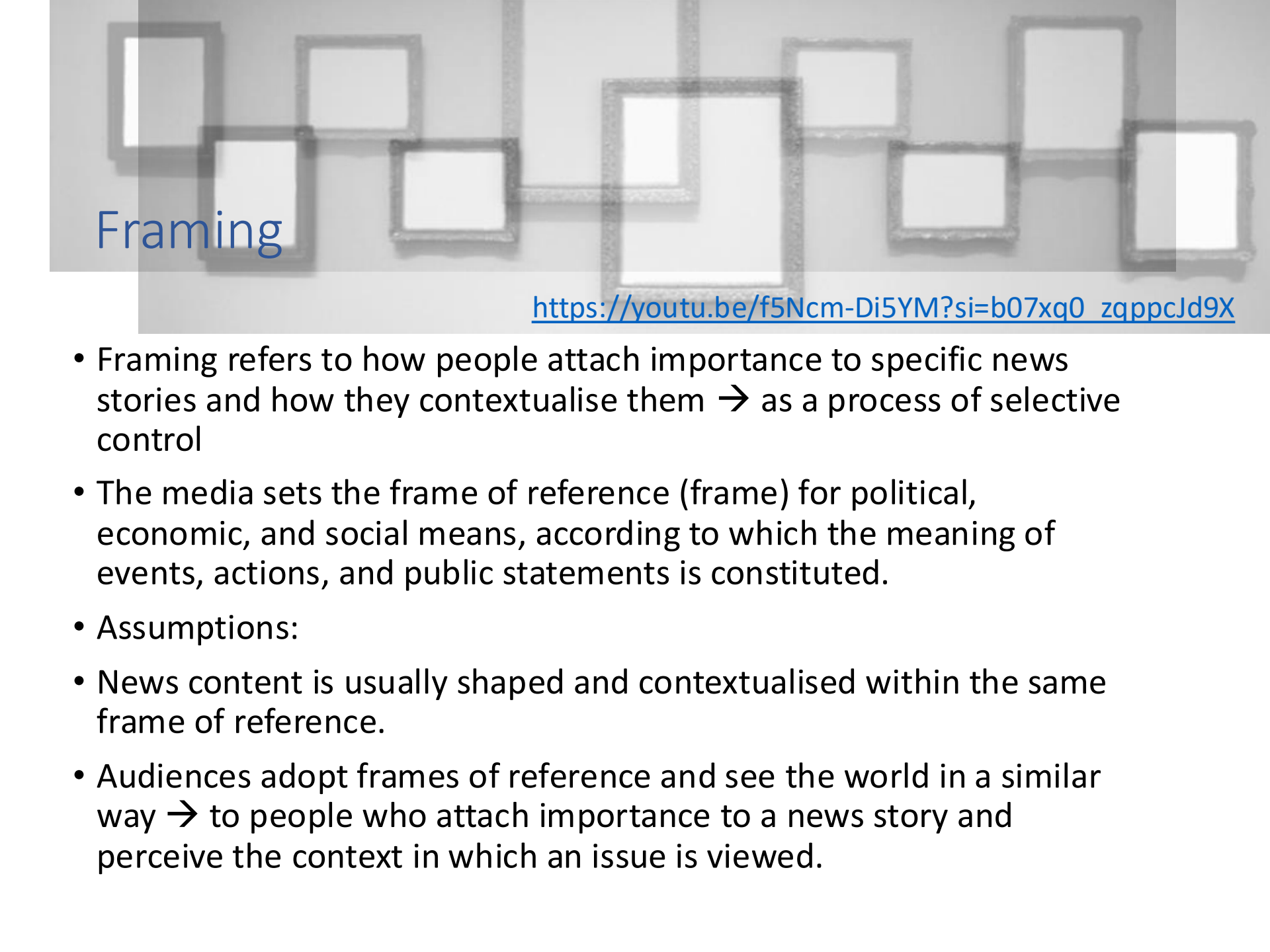


The media has the power to choose, order and prioritise the information it is to present to the public, thus setting not only the media's agenda but also the public's agenda.

Priming

<https://youtu.be/iMEyTtilIXo>

- Priming is the process by which the media, by emphasising certain themes (issues), changes the standards (criteria) by which people evaluate the political agenda and the daily agenda.
- The media gives a certain event a special importance so that it gives people the impression that this news is the most important.
- This is done on a daily basis. The selected news is broadcast as a headline or covered regularly for months.
- Terms such as headlines, special news, discussion, and expert opinion are used.
- The media primes the news by repeating it and giving it more prominence, e.g. the war in Ukraine.



Framing

https://youtu.be/f5Ncm-Di5YM?si=b07xq0_zqppcJd9X

- Framing refers to how people attach importance to specific news stories and how they contextualise them → as a process of selective control
- The media sets the frame of reference (frame) for political, economic, and social means, according to which the meaning of events, actions, and public statements is constituted.
- Assumptions:
 - News content is usually shaped and contextualised within the same frame of reference.
 - Audiences adopt frames of reference and see the world in a similar way → to people who attach importance to a news story and perceive the context in which an issue is viewed.

Third-person effects

<https://youtu.be/UAsIWdGWEuc>

- Davison (1983) defines the third-person effect hypothesis as the likelihood that members of an audience exposed to persuasive communication expect communication to have a more significant effect on others than on themselves.
- The third-person effect is the belief that the media will not have an influence on oneself but rather on others --> this belief of the media's impact on others may motivate us to act or respond in such a way, not because we are influenced, but because we believe others might be.
- This difference in perception may not only explain people's support for limiting free speech on various issues but may also have implications for public policy and other social factors.
- We may be more resistant to being influenced by advertising, especially if we perceive it as pure manipulation or propaganda. Still, we may not make such an assessment about the content of the news.

Strong effects model (conclusion)



The impact of mass communication theories in the study of social media Luoma-Aho (2010).

- Reconsidering the two-step flow of communication
 - The flow of information has grown exponentially.
 - Opinion leaders are no longer mainly politicians or people of authority, but many bloggers and microbloggers, who are basically media producers, are also opinion leaders who broadcast their own interpretations.
 - Opinions take new turns when people post their opinions on their social networks, and unintended consequences can arise when translation services translate messages and posts between cultures and languages.
 - Opinion leaders continue to play an important role in shaping opinions, although not so much in mediating information as in targeting opinions to specific audiences.
 - Today's opinion leaders could be called 'attention' leaders, as their main strengths are no longer opinions but directing attention.

The impact of mass communication theories in the study of social media Luoma-Aho (2010).

- Agenda-setting theory changes in several ways
 - While some individuals aim to become citizen journalists and writers, others accidentally become citizen journalists by being on the scene while something important is happening around them.
 - When many people have mobile communication devices with cameras and internet access wherever they are, they can shape and shape the agenda faster than traditional media.
 - In many parts of the Western world, traditional media institutions are disappearing, so there is a vacuum for agenda-setting.
 - With the introduction of new media, the leading role of large media institutions is diminishing, and selective exposure is becoming the norm
 - People gather their personal and specific news and information from many sources, both professional and non-professional.

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Selective exposure

Users can easily customize their information flow, so they get more consistent information that supports their existing beliefs and filter out as much inconsistent information as they want.



Social media not only helps disseminate more information at a faster rate, but also allows users to access information more selectively. Although faced with an infinite variety of information, social media users can limit their exposure to certain information they find objectionable. Thus, social media use could exacerbate media and citizen fragmentation, narrowing rather than broadening people's political horizons.



Iyengar and Hahn (2009) argue that information overload in the new media environment can further reinforce selective exposure. They point out that when candidates, interest groups and voters all converge on the internet, the possibility of selective exposure to political information increases.

- Messing & Westwood (2014) argue that social network-based information, such as online news, fundamentally alters the context in which news reading occurs.
 - Social media provides a venue that promotes exposure to news from politically diverse people
 - this exposure serves to emphasise social value rather than party affiliation.
 - the two researchers found that the social endorsement generated among social media users increases the likelihood that people will select information
 - the mere presence of social endorsement serves to reduce political selectivity to levels that may, however, be random

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